Report card comments for struggling students

Build each comment in five parts: **a real strength**, **the difficulty** (what the student does, not a label), **what school is doing**, **one thing to try at home**, and an honest, hopeful close. Swap [Name] and "their" for the student's name and pronoun, and the support for what you are really giving.

Positive openers

- [Name] is a kind classmate who notices when others need help.
- [Name] keeps trying when work is difficult, which is one of the most useful habits a learner can have.
- [Name] is getting better at asking for help when something doesn't make sense.
- [Name] brings thoughtful ideas to our class discussions.
- [Name] has a creative imagination that shows in their stories, drawings and projects.
- [Name] is quick to help, whether that's handing out books or showing a new student around.
- [Name] listens carefully to others and responds respectfully.
- [Name] asks great questions and is curious about how things work.
- [Name] comes alive in hands-on work, such as experiments, building and practical tasks.
- [Name] brings real energy and enthusiasm to PE.
- [Name] explains their thinking clearly when talking it through.
- [Name] works well in a team and is a loyal friend.
- [Name] comes into class with a positive attitude and a smile.

Lines by area

Reading: fluency and decoding

- **CONCERN** [Name] is still building their reading fluency and finds longer texts hard to read independently.
- **CONCERN** [Name] is working hard at reading but still finds longer words tricky to read accurately.
- **IF SERIOUS** [Name] is reading below the level we'd expect at this point in the year, so this support is a priority.
- **SUPPORT** To help, we're working on reading aloud more smoothly and breaking longer words into parts in a small reading group several times a week.
- **AT HOME** At home, you could read together for ten minutes most days, taking turns page by page.

Reading: understanding what they read

- **CONCERN** [Name] reads the words accurately but finds it hard to explain what a text was about.
- **CONCERN** [Name] is still learning to pick out the main idea and the important details in a text.
- **IF SERIOUS** Understanding what [Name] reads is affecting work in other subjects too, so this is our main focus.
- **SUPPORT** To help, we're working on stopping to check understanding and retelling the main idea in a sentence or two, with short retell questions in guided reading.
- **AT HOME** At home, you could ask [Name] to tell you what happened in each chapter in a sentence or two.

Writing

- **CONCERN** [Name] has good ideas but finds it hard to get them down on paper in full sentences.
- **CONCERN** [Name] is finding longer pieces of writing difficult and often stops after a few lines.
- **IF SERIOUS** Writing is the area where [Name] needs the most support right now.
- **SUPPORT** To help, we're working on planning ideas before writing and writing in complete sentences, with planning frames and sentence starters.
- **AT HOME** At home, you could let [Name] say a sentence out loud before writing it, for cards, lists or a diary.

Spelling and handwriting

- **CONCERN** [Name] is still learning many common spellings, which can make their writing hard to read.
- **CONCERN** [Name] is working on letter formation and spacing, and handwriting can slow their writing down.
- **SUPPORT** To help, we're working on learning a few key spellings each week and forming letters clearly, with short daily spelling and handwriting practice.
- **AT HOME** At home, you could practice this week's spellings for five minutes a day, writing each word and checking it.

Math: number facts

- **CONCERN** [Name] is still building quick recall of math facts, which slows down work on longer problems.
- **CONCERN** [Name] knows some math facts but often counts on fingers for the rest.
- **SUPPORT** To help, we're working on learning their number facts by heart, with short daily fact practice and games.
- **AT HOME** At home, you could practice a few facts for five minutes a day, with a game, flashcards or an app the school recommends.

Math: problem solving

- **CONCERN** [Name] finds word problems tricky and isn't yet sure which operation to use.
- **CONCERN** [Name] can follow a method with help but finds it hard to solve problems independently.
- **IF SERIOUS** [Name] is not yet working at the level we'd expect in math, so this support is a priority.
- **SUPPORT** To help, we're working on reading a problem twice and drawing a picture or model before solving it, with worked examples in a small group.
- **AT HOME** At home, you could ask [Name] to explain how a homework question was solved, step by step.

Focus and attention

- **CONCERN** [Name] finds it hard to stay focused during longer independent tasks and sometimes misses instructions.
- **CONCERN** [Name] is easily distracted during independent work, so tasks are often left unfinished.
- **SUPPORT** To help, we're working on staying on task for 15 minutes at a time, by breaking tasks into short chunks with a quick check-in after each one.
- **AT HOME** At home, you could use a timer for homework: 15 minutes of work, a short break, then 15 more.

Talking or calling out in class

- **CONCERN** [Name] often chats with classmates during lessons, which means instructions are sometimes missed.
- **CONCERN** [Name] is enthusiastic to share ideas, but often calls out rather than waiting for a turn.
- **SUPPORT** To help, we're working on choosing the right times to talk and share ideas, with a quiet signal we agreed together and plenty of chances to talk with a partner.
- **AT HOME** At home, you could talk about when chatting is great and when it's time to listen.

Missing or unfinished work

- **CONCERN** [Name] has several assignments missing this quarter, and this is affecting their grades.
- **CONCERN** [Name] often leaves classwork unfinished or doesn't hand in homework on time.
- **IF SERIOUS** The missing work is now the main thing holding their grades back, so catching up on it is the first priority.
- **SUPPORT** To help, we're working on handing in every assignment on time, with a weekly checklist of what's due, which we go through together on Mondays.
- **AT HOME** At home, you could check the planner or class page together each evening and agree a regular homework time.

Organization

- **CONCERN** [Name] often arrives without the materials needed and finds it hard to keep track of papers.
- **CONCERN** [Name] finds it hard to keep their work and belongings organized, so things are often lost.
- **SUPPORT** To help, we're working on keeping a tidy folder and packing their bag the night before, with a simple folder system and an end-of-day checklist.
- **AT HOME** At home, you could pack the school bag together the night before.

Confidence

- **CONCERN** [Name] often doubts their own ability and is reluctant to share answers or try harder problems.
- **CONCERN** [Name] is quiet in class and rarely joins in with discussions, even when sure of the answer.
- **SUPPORT** To help, we're working on having a go at challenging work and sharing ideas in class, with chances to share with a partner first and praise for effort and good strategies.
- **AT HOME** At home, you could praise effort and strategies ("you kept going") as well as results.

Managing frustration and behavior

- **CONCERN** [Name] sometimes finds it hard to manage their reactions when frustrated, especially in games and group work.
- **CONCERN** [Name] sometimes finds it hard to stay calm when things don't go to plan, particularly at recess and lunch.
- **SUPPORT** To help, we're working on using a calm-down strategy and words to solve problems, with a plan we made together and regular check-ins.
- **AT HOME** At home, you could talk through what helps [Name] calm down, and notice it out loud when it happens.

Effort and motivation

- **CONCERN** [Name] isn't yet putting full effort into independent work, and the finished work doesn't yet show what I know is possible.
- **CONCERN** [Name] often rushes work to finish quickly, which leads to avoidable mistakes.
- **SUPPORT** To help, we're working on taking pride in finished work and checking it before handing it in, with clear success criteria and a quick check before work is handed in.
- **AT HOME** At home, you could ask [Name] to show you one piece of work each week and talk about what went well.

Working with others

- **CONCERN** [Name] is still learning to work well in a group and to accept other people's ideas.
- **CONCERN** [Name] prefers to work alone and finds it hard to share tasks in group projects.
- **SUPPORT** To help, we're working on taking turns, listening and sharing jobs in group work, with group roles and practice at disagreeing kindly.
- **AT HOME** At home, you could play board games together, which are great practice at taking turns and losing well.

Attendance or lateness

- **CONCERN** [Name] has missed a number of school days this quarter, and catching up on missed lessons is making new work harder.
- **CONCERN** [Name] often arrives late, which means missing the start of our morning lessons.
- **SUPPORT** To help, we're working on catching up on the lessons missed, with missed work shared on our class page and short catch-up sessions.
- **AT HOME** If anything is making mornings or school difficult, please let me know so we can help.

Phrases to avoid, rewritten

Instead of	Write
Jordan is lazy.	Jordan often stops working before a task is finished. We're breaking tasks into short steps with a check-in after each one, and he is finishing more work each week.
Mia is unmotivated in math.	Mia is more confident with hands-on math than with written problems. Our next step is showing her working on paper, and she's doing best when she starts with a model.
Leo can't read yet.	Leo is still learning to sound out words and knows many of his letter sounds. He reads with me in a small group every day, and we're working on blending sounds into words.
Sofia is failing science.	Sofia's science grade this quarter is a D, mainly because three lab reports are missing. If she hands them in by 20 November, her grade will be recalculated, and we're working through them together at lunch on Tuesdays.
Ethan talks too much.	Ethan is enthusiastic and full of ideas, but often chats during lessons, which means he misses instructions. We've agreed a quiet signal, and partner talk gives him a time to share.
Amara never does her homework.	Amara has handed in two of the last eight homework tasks. We go through a weekly checklist together on Mondays, and a regular homework time at home would help.
Noah is very disorganized.	Noah often arrives without the materials he needs. We're using a simple folder system and an end-of-day checklist, and packing his bag the night before would help.
Zoe has a bad attitude.	Zoe is still learning to accept feedback when she's frustrated. We've made a plan for what to do when work feels hard, and she used it twice this week.
Sam doesn't listen.	Sam sometimes misses instructions given to the whole class. Sitting near the front and repeating the steps back to me are helping.
Lily is behind the rest of the class in reading.	Lily is reading below the level we'd expect at this point in the year, so she has extra reading in a small group four times a week. She now reads short chapter books with a partner.
Kai makes careless mistakes.	Kai often rushes to finish, which leads to avoidable mistakes. Our next step is checking each answer before handing work in, and he's started using a three-point checklist.
Grace gives up easily.	Grace sometimes stops when a problem looks hard. We're practicing a 'try two ways first' strategy, and she is having a go more often.
Omar is not working to his potential.	Omar's written work doesn't yet show what he explains so well out loud. Our next step is planning his ideas before writing, using a planning frame.
Ruby is disruptive in class.	Ruby is still learning to follow class expectations during group work. We have a plan with clear steps and regular check-ins, and she's had several good days in a row.
Ella is rude to staff.	Ella is still learning to speak respectfully when she disagrees. We're practicing how to raise a problem calmly, and I'd like to talk with you about how we can support her together.
Leo is immature.	Leo is still learning to manage his reactions when a game doesn't go his way. Practicing taking turns and losing well, at school and at home, is helping.
Isla is very shy and won't speak in class.	Isla is quiet in class and rarely joins in with discussions. Sharing with a partner first is helping, and she answered in front of the class twice this month.

Finn needs to try harder, needs to focus and needs to finish his work.	Finn's next step is staying on task for 15 minutes at a time. We're breaking tasks into short chunks with a check-in after each one.
Maya has poor attendance.	Maya has missed 9 days this quarter, and catching up on missed lessons is making new work harder. We share missed work on our class page; if anything is making mornings difficult, please let me know so we can help.
Jack is attention-seeking.	Jack enjoys making the class laugh. Our next step is choosing the right moments for it, and he's taking on a class job that gives him a chance to lead.
Ben's handwriting is messy.	Ben is working on forming his letters clearly and leaving spaces between words. Five minutes of handwriting practice each day is helping.
Ava probably has ADHD.	Don't write it. Talk to the family in person and follow your school's process. The report can describe what you see and what helps: "Ava finds it hard to stay focused in longer tasks, and short chunks with check-ins are helping."
Since his parents split up, Theo has been upset.	Leave family news out. "Theo is getting better at asking for help when something is bothering him, and a quiet check-in each morning is helping."
Priya is in the bottom group for maths.	Priya is working on her number facts and on reading word problems carefully. She has extra maths practice in a small group, and she now knows her 2, 5 and 10 times tables.
Eli is a slow learner.	Eli works carefully and needs a little more time to practice new skills. Short, regular practice is helping new skills stick.
Chloe could do better if she applied herself.	Chloe's next step is checking her work before handing it in. When she does, her answers are much more accurate.
Oscar is a pleasure to have in class, but he is struggling.	Oscar is kind to everyone and quick to help. In reading, he is still building fluency, so he reads with me in a small group every day.
Hana's IEP goals are not being met.	Leave the plan out of the report card unless your school says otherwise; review it in the plan meeting. The comment can say: "Hana is working on reading longer words, with extra practice in a small group."

106 lines. Free from polytheseus.com/teacher-skills/guides/report-card-comments-for-struggling-students, where a free builder puts them together and checks the wording. Drafted with AI help: read every line against what you know of the student and your school's report rules before you use it.